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CMPM 180

Project 1: Artist Statement

Since being introduced to kinetic poetry and moving texts at the beginning of the summer session, I couldn't wrap my head around how these pieces were made to be inaccessible, like how a poem might force you to constantly move your mouse to "dust off" a line before it gets covered back up. Somehow the readings for week 2 made the concept even more difficult to me as we brought in nature and what is natural into the mix.

The Ong text was the reading I felt like I engaged with the most out of this weeks reading because I read this passage and it stuck in my head for days: "Nevertheless, by contrast with natural, oral speech, writing is completely artificial [...] Oral speech is fully natural to human beings in the sense that every human being in every culture who is not physiologically or psychologically impaired learns to talk." (Ong 31). From my perspective, writing seems about as natural as cave paintings. Writing would be as natural as any other form of art human beings experience and enjoy throughout history. With the book's logic, dance could be something artificial, most communities have dance but its not in *every* culture, some religious communities forbid dancing.

The back and forth in my mind of what's considered natural and what's not made my head hurt and for this project I wanted to capture that frustration. I wanted to go to a place that I know is both definitely artificial and inaccessible. Before I knew I wanted to target something that was artificial, I wanted to think about something that was just inaccessible; my first thought was language and translation, since language barriers seem like the only accessibility 'issue' I would have to deal with in my life and I knew other people also would struggle with being faced with an unfamiliar language too. I was still at odds with this though because I felt like it was still a barrier that could be overcome.

Jumping back to my issues with inaccessibility, when we were first introduced to kinetic poetry, to me, it didn't seem like those with disabilities were an afterthought; it felt like they were being purposefully excluded from the art. I do not know the intentions of any of the creators, though, so I cannot say that is the case. So what I wanted to say with my project was, 'Why only exclude a select few when you could exclude everyone?' and I feel like that idea also pairs well with the idea of artificial. I think humans evolved to share, which is why we have communities and civilizations, so I think it would be unnatural to do the complete opposite. I can't remember when I made the initial connection, but I recalled my cryptography class I took earlier this year in the winter, and I felt something click in my brain. I felt that cryptography and encryption captured these feelings of frustration perfectly, and I wanted my users to experience that frustration too.

My project is a page with a simple message: "This message was not meant for you." Except that message was encrypted with a Caesar cipher. The users wouldn't know that there is an encrypted message on the page; they would just see random letters on the screen. The users do have a chance to find out the meaning of the message, though, if they can click the message the right number of times. There are 26 possible variations of the phrase corresponding to the number of ways you can shift the alphabet with the Caesar cipher. Upon loading the page, the program randomly chooses one variation, and once the user clicks the phrase the number of times associated with that variation, the message is revealed.

As the user clicks the message, it shakes side to side, giving the impression of a mistyped password being entered into a log-in screen. With every shake, the user would get more and more frustrated with the random sequence of letters on the screen. I would imagine many users being intrigued by the first click and possibly excited to see if anything would happen, and I would hope these users get the 26th variation of the message, so we could see if the excitement would eventually give way to frustration.